Session 20

2025-08-24

1 - Waking in the fungus

~06:00, 14 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Dawn comes thin behind a dense fog and the party wakes to the *pop, pop, pop* of caps still bursting out of the ground. The stone layer Nyx proposed the night before has kept their immediate radius clear; beyond that, everyone else in the caravan sits pinned in whatever small patch they overnighted in, wolves audible somewhere in the fog.
2. Each cap shrieks when it is touched or set swinging and vents a small cloud of black spores; the spores force anyone caught in the cloud to feel the fungus's own agony. No merchant will set a foot into the field.
3. Amidamaru, arms crossed, mutters that this is what the **Company of the Boar** are being paid for and can handle themselves — he is essentially paying to be on this caravan, not the other way around. Eguzkilore joins Nyx by the wagon and stays close; one of them asks **Eldkin**, the dwarven caravan veteran, for a shovel — she leans out of her wagon-bed with great care not to touch anything and tosses one across.
4. Amidamaru whispers a magical message across the road to **Thorvin** of the Company — *"¿Qué vais a hacer con los hongos? ¿necesitais ayuda?"* — and waits for the reply, but none comes. After a quick study of the fungus, he sends a second message: *"El fuego podría limpiarlas más rápido"*, and turns to the rest to say the caps are venomous but passable if the skin is protected.

2 - Clearing the road

1. Amidamaru sends Munin out to the far edge of his telepathic tether — a hundred feet of road — and from the air the owl can see what the fog has been hiding: the field of caps runs on another considerable stretch past that point, up to a small rise where the fog itself breaks and the caps appear to run out.
2. From there Munin starts burning a cart-wide corridor outward, breathing out a cone of flame with every wing-beat; the fire kills the caps cleanly and each burst quiets a shriek, but the dying caps release their spores all the same and Munin catches hundreds of little pulses of pain through the clouds; Amidamaru feels the owl's small chest tighten through the bond.
3. Nyx, meanwhile — a spare cloth from her kit tied over her nose and mouth against the spores — walks the road from the caravan side out toward the clearing's near edge, a hundred feet of careful, measured steps that thread between caps, with only a spore-puff or two set off along the way. When she reaches the cleared part of the road she turns and starts hammering back with the shovel toward the caravan, letting the spores settle before continuing.
4. **Mialee** pulls a torch from the wagon, dips it in a smear of the oil she keeps, and pushes it forward with her invisible mage-hand along the mid-line of the road, burning a narrow path ten feet wide back toward the party.
5. Amidamaru sends Munin on a second pass — finish the far end, then clean what he can out of the middle on the way back. The owl manages the far end, but on the return flight he can go no further; a few strides from where Nyx is working, he picks her out instead of flying on to Amidamaru and lands on her shoulder — an owl who had never let her touch him before, now clinging to her as a little ball, utterly wretched.
6. The caravan's own start trying it and mostly break. **Eldkin** picks up a torch, gets a few paces in, and curls into a ball on the ground, weeping — the spore-pain overwhelms her — and several others do the same. The Company of the Boar clear their whole side without a break, and their leader **Jorath** crosses the road to check on the party, kneels by Eldkin and gives her a swallow from a small canteen that steadies her.
7. **Lai**, seeing Eldkin starting to come around, picks the torch up himself, turns to Eguzkilore with a pointed look — *are you going to help or what?* — and Eguzkilore takes the torch and goes forward into the clearing to work it alongside Mialee's mage-hand for the final stretch.
8. When the two groups meet in the middle and the fog lifts, the applause runs mostly to the Company of the Boar. Amidamaru calls out over it — *he* had set the first fire. But the caravan's eyes stay where they were: the Company had worked their whole patch in plain sight, start to finish. Of the party, only Nyx had been visibly in it — shovel in hand at the far edge of the clearing — while the rest stood idle, until Eguzkilore picked up a torch at the very end.

3 – The dropped amulet

~19:00, 14 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The road holds no more surprises. That evening, at supper, Amidamaru signals Mialee that it is time to act, sits close to the first of the men they believe rides for the cult, and spreads his papers, diary sheets, and the dragon-shaped amulet in plain view before getting up to fetch a fresh pencil from a wagon.
2. Mialee, at prudent distance, flicks her invisible mage-hand and blows the papers up into the air across the cultist's group as if a gust had lifted them. The suspected men gather the sheets, glance at them but do not read, and one picks up the amulet — which speaks in a small careful voice: *"Amidamaru, tú eres el elegido, nos veremos pronto"*.
3. When Amidamaru returns the men are all watching him. One states carefully that his papers had fallen and his dragon amulet had spoken a message aloud. Amidamaru fakes a startle and asks what it said; the man simply looks away — the read is guarded, not quite hostile. He and Mialee compare notes by silent message: everyone reacted the same, no one broke, the plan had done nothing.
4. Watches split as usual: Eguzkilore takes the first, the Company of the Boar take the second and third — the caravan's regard for them keeps climbing.

4 – The Trollclaws

~08:00, 15 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The day passes without event. The caravan runs its usual rhythm: wake-up and breakfast on the roadside, three hours march, a long midday halt for lunch, three more hours of road in the afternoon, another halt, and the final two hours push before camping for the night. At each stop Amidamaru works his way down the line to **Lord Kaldur**'s cart — the noble's horses are limping and raw again from his ill treatment — and lays hands on them one at a time; by now it has settled into the routine.
2. The next morning the landscape thins, the burial mounds run out, and the party can begin to smell the marshes ahead — where the road climbs into low hills. Eldkin comes up alongside Nyx and, in a low voice, tells her they are entering troll country; similar warnings ripple through the other groups. The Company of the Boar loosen weapons in their sheaths for easier draw. Nyx asks Eldkin how often the trolls attack — almost never, only once worth mentioning across all her trips, plus one lone creature met by accident — and tells her she will scout ahead.
3. Amidamaru sends Munin high to watch the woods — from the air the vegetation here is visibly lusher than anything the caravan has crossed since the Fields of the Dead — and tells **Nuberroca** it is game country: if he wants meat for the caravan, this is the place.

5 - Ordning

~11:00, 16 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Nuberroca peels off to hunt. Munin drifts near him; both spot the same thing at once — a troll sat in a marsh almost two hundred feet off, happily eating a fish. Nuberroca rages — a mix of excitement and caution after so many days of boredom — and starts his approach, trying for stealth despite his size and his almost total inexperience at it. Munin returns to Amidamaru fluttering and pecking at his clothes, unable to explain through their bond what he has seen.
2. He closes to a rock about a hundred feet out from the troll's back. At that distance the troll catches his scent on the marsh wind, finishes its fish, and comes for him at a run, shouting the giant word for *food*.
3. Nuberroca throws a ration underhand, grows to match the troll's height and slightly overtake it, and calls out in giant: *"Creature, friend or foe?"*. The troll pulls up, takes the ration in a single bite, and replies a single word: *"Ordning?"* — something that translates roughly as *hierarchy*.
4. Nuberroca answers *"Me, king. Me, chief."* and gives it another ration. The troll pushes him experimentally; Nuberroca holds ground, calls out *"strong, strong, friends, we want to pass, no fight"* and tosses more rations. He flexes and puts a hand on the troll's shoulder — *"strong"* — the troll pushes his hand off without effort. He asks about the troll's chief; the troll only echoes *"chief"*.
5. ***[EPIC]*** By the time the rest of the party arrives at a prudent distance in cover, Amidamaru has reached out magically to ask what is going on, and Nuberroca whispers a reply back: *"todo controlado, estoy haciendo amigos"*. Nuberroca offers a final ration, says *"goodbye, friend"*; the troll takes it, gives him a puzzled look, and mutters *"Ordning"* before walking away. Nuberroca — running low on rations — returns to the caravan grinning, still giant-sized, and scares half the wagons stiff.

6 - Jorath's offer

1. On the march after, Jorath comes up alongside Nuberroca — the story travelled the moment he arrived doubled in size — and offers him a place in the Company of the Boar: they are always ready to take on another hand.
2. Nuberroca declines — he is already in another company, riding with this caravan only for the journey, and only for pay. Jorath drops the pitch and pulls back to the head of his group, a little embarrassed at the rebuff.

7 - Dinner and the cult

~20:00, 16 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Before turning in, Amidamaru pulls Nyx and Mialee aside — the plan on the table is to snatch, torture, and squeeze information out, with Nuberroca as the interrogator. Mialee approves, she is not going to oppose the plan. Amidamaru is careful about which specific cultist to target, he has grown fond of Paco.
2. Options are canvassed. Mialee proposes false troll-tracks to frame a snatch; Amidamaru worries about the audience Jorath's group now provides — that *company of the golden-fish* of theirs means more witnesses if the party is seen. The window is Eguzkilore's watch, though for some odd reason the caravan does not adore Eguzkilore the way they adore the Company of the Boar for burning a few caps.
3. Mialee turns to Nyx and asks whether she has an alternative plan. Nyx puts a floor on the risk: snatching someone roughly and interrogating them aggressively could mark a before-and-after in the party's standing with the caravan, and set off a hell of a mess right where they stood. The party's history of interrogation is bad — only the dwarf of Greenest ever got a cultist to talk, and never gently. They settle on waiting for a distraction — a troll attack, if it comes — to move under cover of chaos.
4. Nyx works the geography backwards: if the suspected cultists are riding this caravan all the way to Waterdeep, then **Naerytar** must sit near Waterdeep itself. Mialee adds that it is probably the stop just before the city, or a short detour off the road a day short of it.
5. Amidamaru walks over to **Selvek** the mute brother and, under the cover of small talk, sends him a magical whisper asking whether he knows where Naerytar is. Selvek's reply comes back as a thought: no, he does not.
6. Watches split as before: first Eguzkilore, then two and three for the Company of the Boar.

8 - The trolls come

~06:00, 17 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Screaming from a guard next to Nuberroca wakes the camp: a troll has yanked him from his bedroll and, in one bite, tears off half his neck, blood spattering the couple Nuberroca had been sleeping beside.
2. Nuberroca scans the camp — the Company of the Boar is nowhere to be seen. The party stands alongside the merchants and whichever guards are still awake.
3. Nuberroca is on the troll before it can release the guard. He moves to shield the couple, lets the fury take him, and drives his polearm into it, calling out *"Ordning"* on the strike. He swings recklessly, and again on the next beat; the troll goes down under him, wounded but still moving.
4. The goliath yells for the rest of the camp to fall back — these things are fast and strong. He demands aloud where the merchants who fired them and the Company who took the contract have gone. *"Que se los coman vivos"*, he says when told they must all be on the other side of the camp.
5. Amidamaru opens the party's magical answer, summoning a blade of shadow at his hand and closing on the troll Nuberroca has just dropped, striking with a resonant blow that hums after the swing. A camp sergeant follows up with a lance-thrust while the troll is sprawled, finishing it off in a chorus of pain.
6. Behind the party, the first troll — thought dead on the ground — hauls itself back up on half-regenerated limbs, grabs the sergeant by the back, and bites deep into his neck.
7. Fresh trolls come in from the woods. On the pack's first charge, Nuberroca sweeps his polearm into a charging troll at full stride and knocks it flat before it can close.
8. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore drops back a step, pours a flask of oil over the arrows in his quiver, sinks his torch upright in the ground, and starts firing arrows through the flame so each shaft carries a small tongue of fire into the oncoming pack.
9. Mialee — knowing trolls burn but not much else — throws up a phantom bonfire near the incoming trolls, betting on their brute wit to route them around it; two of the trolls take it as real and hesitate around the illusion, one shrugs it off.
10. Amidamaru weaves the sword-song into his movement and hurls a chromatic orb of fire into a wounded troll — the ball bursts in its chest and starts melting the slime off it. Munin, high overhead, breathes out another cone of fire over three of the trolls together, dropping one and burning the rest badly.
11. Kaelthar joins the fight — a pale light wrapping him, a dead run at the nearest troll on the ground — and strikes down into it hard, then again on the backswing. Between swings he lets loose his fire breath — one troll drops, the other stays up but hurt. A moment later a bite tears into him, a troll's claw slips past his guard and the pale light around him winks out.
12. Nyx picks target after target with the longbow, settling into a rhythm — one shot, step, pick again — and chews through the badly-wounded trolls one by one; early in the fight she puts one on the ground with a particularly devastating opening shot. Nuberroca lays a hand on Amidamaru's shoulder; something fierce passes between them and Amidamaru steadies. Mialee slips an arrow in from the flank where the troll cannot see her. Eguzkilore follows up with a shot straight into a downed troll to make sure it does not get up.
13. With most of the pack down, Nuberroca grows huge again mid-swing and roars *"ORDNING"* at the last standing trolls. The last troll to reach Amidamaru chips pieces off his shell with claws but breaks nothing he cannot heal. When the last of them is down, Munin lands and torches one with a final cone of fire; Amidamaru salutes — *he plays like a dragon*.

9 - Aftermath

1. Four of the defenders lie dead and three are wounded — a battered sergeant, another guard bleeding badly, and **Paco**, mostly untouched. Two of the fallen are guards the party had marked as cultists. The merchants and civilians are all alive — the guards took the bill.
2. The Company of the Boar is confirmed gone — not among the dead, not anywhere in the camp — and four of the caravan's horses are missing with them.
3. Amidamaru lays a healing on the wounded; Paco politely refuses, telling him he is holding up. Meanwhile Mialee moves to search the bodies of the guards they had marked as cultists, finding some spare coin but nothing useful.
4. By the fire, Amidamaru and Nuberroca argue over the credit — Amidamaru claims every troll kill; Nuberroca insists he speared each one and never saw them get back up.